

1980 SLV-3 LAUNCHED

The New Frontier

The launch of the indigenously built satellite launch vehicle kicks off a new space era

Former president APJ Abdul Kalam will never forget August 10, 1979. Nine years ago, Vikram Sarabhai had given a pep talk to him in an ancient church at Thumba, a fishing village near Thiruvananthapuram, about how India should develop the ability to launch satellites into orbit. But now he was seeing the hard work of several years being washed away, literally. When he should have been celebrating the launch of Satellite Launch Vehicle (SLV)-3, the then project director of the programme was sitting sombrely in a press conference. The SLV-3 took off, but within minutes, because of a faulty valve, it plunged into the Bay of Bengal. His boss, Satish Dhawan, chairman of the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), took the blame. Kalam got the message. Exactly 11 months later, at 8.03 a.m. on July 18, 1980, the rocket blasted off from Sriharikota in Orissa with a 35-kg satellite called Rohini, launching India into an exclusive club of nations

that could indigenously develop the technology needed to launch satellites. Dhawan again had Kalam by his side at the press conference, this time giving him all the credit. The SLV-3 was a 22-metre long, four-stage vehicle weighing 17 tonnes. It put three Rohini satellites into orbit, in 1980, 1981 and 1983. Since then, India has taken long strides in launch vehicle technology with the operationalisation of the Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV) and Geosynchronous Satellite Launch Vehicle (GSLV). Chandrayaan, India's first unmanned lunar probe was also launched by a modified

version of the PSLV. It was Chandrayaan which, for the first time, found water on the moon, corroborated by the National Aeronautics and Space Administration (NASA). Quite an achievement if you compare ISRO's budget of Rs 4,959 crore for 2009-10 with that of NASA's \$17 billion (Rs 79,000 crore) for the same period. No wonder, with most projects aimed at applications like broadcasting, telemedicine or distance learning for its far-flung populations, ISRO has, for long, given preference to the practical use of space science over military utility. *by Stephen David*

THE MAIN EVENT

Indira Back in Power

Since the Congress Party was returned to power with 351 of the 524 seats contested in the seventh Lok Sabha, there is a feeling of hope for a new beginning in the country which has stood still while the Janata Party bosses staged what could only be described as a *Kissa Kursi Ka* show. "Indira Gandhi could well be crowned the Empress of India considering her spectacular victory," said an admirer. The 62-year-old looked like a queen whose lost crown was being restored to her by the nation after being banished for 34 months. Not one hair in her streak of white was out of place. She radiated charm in her golden silk sari. As she presented herself for the oath of office, a pregnant silence laden with emotion spread in the Rashtrapati Bhavan's plush Ashoka Hall. Every seat on the 758-sq-yard floor was occupied. *India Today, January 16-21, 1980*



INDIRA GANDHI WELCOMED BY HER SUPPORTERS

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- Sanjay Gandhi dies as the Pitts S-2A aircraft he was flying crashes in Delhi
- The BJP is born
- In Bhagalpur, the police blind 31 undertrials by pouring acid into their eyes